have discussed, Mr. Chairman, in the Security Assistance bill that this committee approved last Wednesday.

As you are aware, Mr. Chairman, prior to the markup we reached an agreement that I would cosponsor the bill and seek the support of all my Republican colleagues with provisions included in the text that I believed were necessary to prevent North Korea from being prematurely removed from the list of state sponsors of terrorism, and to ensure that any agreement with North Korea be truly verifiable. The members of this committee then endorsed this agreement when they rendered their unanimous support for the Security Assistance bill containing the compromise language.

To my great surprise, less than a day after the committee's vote that agreement was essentially tossed aside and my staff was presented with a revised text negotiated between the Democrat majority of this committee and the leaders of the Senate Appropriations and Foreign Relations Committees which weakened the provisions in this agreement that we had worked out with the chairman, and again supported by members of this committee. The new text was a fait accompli, as efforts to restore elements of these provisions were effectively ignored.

Mr. Chairman, if we are to proceed in a cooperative manner we need to be certain that agreements that have been negotiated in good faith with you and the members of the majority will be honored throughout and not unilaterally reopened or set aside whenever circumstances change. And I hope that trust and confidence can be restored. In our brief conversation before today's hearing, Mr. Chairman, you assured me that this will not happen again. I thank you. I trust you. And I trust that the dedicated, hard-working staff continues our bipartisan approach.

Turning to the subject of today's hearing, Mr. Chairman, the Afghan-Pakistan border region is of critical geostrategic importance and the United States must continue to work closely with both the Afghan and Pakistani Governments to counter common enemies that are exploiting ungoverned territory in that region. The recent and highly significant democratic transition in Islamabad opens up exciting new opportunities for the people of Pakistan and for the future of United States-Pakistan relations.

The United States congratulates Pakistan on the success of its recent elections. Despite enormous odds, the will of the people prevailed. And although the new government still enjoys strong public support, it also confronts a daunting agenda, from strengthening Parliament and other civilian institutions, to bolstering an independent judiciary and the rule of law, and working through challenges of rising energy demand and skyrocketing food prices.

With respect to critically important security challenges, in the long run the best antidote for Islamic extremism should be a legitimately elected government that can fight this threat with the backing of the Pakistani people. In the short run, however, new uncertainties have emerged that our two governments must tackle together.

The good news is that Pakistan's new government has correctly identified the need to develop a comprehensive counterinsurgency plan, including economic and social development and the integration of the tribal areas into the mainstream of the greater society.

The goal of this plan is to eliminate safe havens and to marginalize the appeal of local militants.

Contrary to popular misconceptions, this new approach largely dovetails with an evolving U.S. strategy premised on the understanding that military efforts alone have not eliminated extremist recruitment, training or operations in the tribal areas, and that countering extremist

Copyright © 2010. Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated. All rights reserved.

Combating Islamic Militancy and Terrorism in Pakistan's Border Region, Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated, 2010. ProQuest Ebook Central,